

AppBazar: An Android market for India

There is no doubt about the fact that India is the hottest market for telecom and telecom-related hardware. Gartner predicts that by 2014, India's telecom market would be so developed that most of its people would be using a smartphone! Sensing this opportunity, many mobile phone companies and independent Web and app development companies have been gearing themselves up in the recent past. Also, the Android revolution is on the verge of hitting India with many Indian companies readying their low-cost Android phones this quarter.

In such a scenario, there would be a huge demand for apps. And not just any application, but those that are customised to Indian tastes, habits and usage sensibilities. Webonise Lab, a Pune-based start-up, has taken the initiative to develop India-specific apps and launch its own version of the Android market for India – AppBazar. This app store is slated to hit the market sometime in April this year. The company is currently readying its store and hosting a developer challenge to get the dev community engaged.

The developer challenge, which has been on since January 26, is open to freelancers, students, the developer community and practically anyone who is interested in the Android platform. More information can be found on contest.mobinise.com.

Speaking about the idea and the focus of the company, Shardul Mohite, CEO, Webonise Lab, shares, "Our target is the Tier 1, 2 and 3 cities. With mobile manufacturers joining hands with Android to woo the common Indian user, there is a huge opportunity for the development of India-specific content. We intend to give the users a new mobile experience with an Indian background, and that too, in their own respective languages."

Firefox criticises IE9

Internet Explorer's newest version is undergoing final testing and would be available to consumers soon. However, it has run into rough weather with its arch-rival Firefox. One of the technology evangelists with Firefox, Paul Rouget, criticised the new browser for not being able to support common Web standards. He wrote in a blog post, "IE9 is definitely better than IE8 and is step in the right direction, but I don't believe it to be a truly modern browser."

He went ahead and claimed that IE9 is actually two years' behind the latest release of Firefox. Reacting to Microsoft's claim that IE9 is built to support most of the Web encoded in HTML5, Rouget said that Microsoft's claims were based on internal testing and not on industry standards.

Firefox even referred to an independent testing that proves the fact that Firefox complies with more than 87 per cent of Web standards overall compared to 61 per cent of that of IE9. Microsoft has rubbished the claims made by Mozilla in its own blog post saying, "Test the depth of an implementation or how well the feature's behaviour matches the standard." Rouget has also listed a set of 17 technical features that are absent from the latest release of IE9.

Google tried to woo Nokia

Eric Schmidt, outgoing CEO of Google, revealed at the Mobile World Congress (MWC) that Google did try to woo Nokia to get it on-board with Android. "We would have loved it if they had chosen Android. They chose the other guys," he said at his keynote speech at the MWC. Nokia announced its partnership with

Mid-range Android Galaxy Ace arrives in India

The Galaxy Ace, which is more or less a copy of the iPhone 4 in design sensibilities, is retailing for Rs 14,990 at shopping site Flipkart.com. Its features include Android 2.2, an 8.9 cm (3.5") HVGA display, a 5 MP camera, an 800 MHz processor, among others. The phone is Rs 3,500 cheaper than the recently launched Motorola Defy, but loses out on the tough form factor and the slightly bigger but higher-resolution WVGA (854 x 480 pixel) display. What would you go with – a cheaper, knocked off version of the iPhone or an original but a pricier model?

Motorola Xoom gets \$799 price tag

Motorola Xoom, which has been attracting enthusiasts as being the first worthy competitor to the iPad and also for being the first tablet shipping with Android Honeycomb, will sell for an unsubsidised \$799 at Verizon Wireless, with its Wi-Fi-only version priced at around \$600.



Sanjay Jha, chief executive, Motorola, told reporters in Barcelona on the sidelines of the Mobile World Congress trade show, that nearly all Motorola products will use Google's Android software this year, which could get a boost from Nokia's pact to start using Microsoft's software. "I am as focused on Android as I ever have been. As a result of Nokia adopting Microsoft, it's possible that some of the other players concentrate on Android," he said.